CASE STUDY – 12

CORPORATE GOVERNANCE & ETHICS POLICY

(Example: Reliance Industries Limited)

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1. INTRODUCTION

Reliance Industries Limited (RIL) is one of India's major diversified companies, with business interests in energy, petrochemicals, retail, digital services and other consumer and industrial activities. Because it operates across different sectors and serves many stakeholders, responsible management and ethical decision-making are important. Corporate governance refers to the systems through which a company is directed, managed and monitored. Business ethics means conducting business with honesty, fairness, integrity and responsibility. This case study explains RIL's governance and ethics framework, key provisions, customer rights, business relevance and possible improvements.

2. POLICY OVERVIEW

RIL publishes corporate governance reports and policies covering ethical conduct, anti-bribery and anti-corruption, related-party transactions, whistleblowing, corporate social responsibility, risk management, data privacy and other governance matters. Its Code of Conduct applies to directors and employees. These policies guide business decisions and support compliance with applicable laws.

The main objectives are to:

- Promote honesty, integrity, fairness and responsible leadership.
- Protect shareholders, customers, employees, suppliers and communities.
- Support compliance with applicable laws and listing requirements.
- Prevent bribery, corruption, fraud and conflicts of interest.
- Provide reporting channels for suspected violations.
- Protect personal information, confidential records and intellectual property.
- Promote safe, fair and respectful working conditions.

3. KEY PROVISIONS OF THE POLICY

- **Honesty and integrity:** Directors and employees are expected to act honestly, comply with company policies and use company resources responsibly.
- **Transparency and disclosure:** The company should provide accurate and timely information about material business and financial matters in accordance
- **Accountability and board oversight:** The Board oversees strategy, management and governance. Board committees support review of audit, risk, remuneration and other matters.
- **Conflict of interest:** Personal relationships or financial interests must not improperly influence business decisions. Potential conflicts should be disclosed and managed.
- **Anti-bribery and anti-corruption:** Employees and representatives must not offer, promise, give, request or accept improper benefits to secure business advantages.
- **Whistleblower mechanism:** The company provides channels for reporting suspected violations or unethical conduct. Good-faith reporters should be protected from retaliation under the relevant policy.
- **Fair employment and human rights:** Workplace practices should promote respect, equal opportunity, dignity and freedom from harassment or discrimination.
- **Privacy and information security:** Personal data and confidential information should be used for legitimate purposes and protected against unauthorised access.
- **Responsible supply chain:** Suppliers and business partners are expected to follow applicable laws and relevant ethical and human-rights standards.
- **Risk management and internal controls:** Policies and controls help identify and manage financial, operational, legal, cyber, safety and reputational risks.

4. COMPLIANCE AND GOVERNANCE ANALYSIS

As a listed Indian company, RIL is subject to applicable requirements under the Companies Act, 2013, the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, and other relevant laws. RIL's corporate governance reports describe its governance structure and processes.

- **Board of Directors:** Oversees company strategy, management and governance responsibilities.
- **Board committees:** The Audit Committee and other relevant committees review matters within their assigned responsibilities.
- **Code of Conduct:** Sets expectations for ethical behaviour and compliance for directors and employees.
- **Vigil Mechanism and Whistle-Blower Policy:** Allows concerns about suspected violations to be raised through designated reporting channels.
- **Internal audit and controls:** Help assess records, safeguard assets and identify control weaknesses.
- **Regulatory disclosures:** Annual reports and other disclosures support shareholder understanding of governance and financial performance.
- **Risk management:** Processes help identify and respond to financial, operational, compliance and other business risks.

5. CUSTOMER RIGHTS

Customer rights matter across RIL's consumer-facing businesses, including retail and digital services. Exact rights and procedures depend on the product, service, contract and applicable law.

- **Right to clear information:** Customers should receive understandable information about products, prices, terms, charges, warranties and conditions.
- **Right to fair treatment:** Customers should be treated respectfully and should not face misleading or unfair business practices.
- **Right to privacy:** Personal information should be handled responsibly and protected against unauthorised access or disclosure.
- **Right to safety and quality:** Products and services should meet applicable safety and quality requirements, with relevant instructions and warnings.
- **Right to raise complaints:** Customers should be able to contact the relevant business or customer-support channel and receive appropriate handling of genuine complaints.
- **Right to accurate transactions:** Bills, payments, refunds and other transactions should be recorded and communicated accurately.
- **Right to legal protection:** Customers retain the protections available under applicable consumer-protection and other laws.

6. POLICY EVALUATION

Strengths:

- RIL publishes corporate governance reports and a range of governance and ethics policies
- The Code of Conduct provides a common foundation for expected behaviour.

- Board and committee oversight supports accountability and review.
- A whistleblower mechanism gives employees a way to raise concerns.
- Anti-corruption, risk management and related-party policies address important risk
- Privacy, human rights, health and safety and responsible sourcing policies address wider stakeholder responsibilities.
- Areas for Continued Improvement
- Continue practical, role-specific ethics and compliance training.
- Make customer complaint routes easy to find across brands and businesses.
- Explain privacy notices and customer-facing terms in clear language.
- Review cybersecurity and data-protection controls regularly.
- Monitor complaint themes and use them to improve products and services.

7. PRACTICAL IMPLEMENTATION

- Provide induction and refresher training on the Code of Conduct and relevant policies.
- Require employees to disclose potential conflicts of interest and follow approval procedures.
- Maintain clear processes for reporting suspected fraud, corruption, harassment or misconduct.
- Use internal audits and risk reviews to test controls.
- Protect customer and employee data through access controls, secure systems and staff awareness.
- Keep accurate financial, purchasing, sales and customer-service records.
- Use supplier checks and contractual expectations to communicate ethical standards.

- Review customer complaints and take corrective action when recurring problems are identified.
- Document investigations appropriately while respecting confidentiality and due process.
- Review policies periodically and communicate material changes to employees.

8. BUSINESS RELEVANCE

- **Customer trust:** Honest information, reliable products and responsible data handling support long-term relationships.
- **Investor confidence:** Transparent disclosures and sound oversight help investors assess performance and governance.
- **Employee engagement:** Fair treatment and clear conduct standards support morale and a respectful workplace.
- **Risk reduction:** Internal controls help identify problems before they cause greater harm.
- **Legal compliance:** Following applicable requirements can reduce penalties, disputes and business disruption.
- **Reputation:** Ethical behaviour strengthens credibility with customers, suppliers, regulators and communities.
- **Sustainable growth:** Responsible decisions support durable relationships and long-term value creation

9. EXAMPLE: RELIANCE INDUSTRIES LIMITED

RIL provides an example of how a large diversified company can establish a formal governance framework. Its published governance report describes a multi-tier structure with defined roles and responsibilities. The Code of Conduct reflects the values Customer Value,

Ownership Mindset, Respect, Integrity, One Team and Excellence. For example, if an employee identifies a possible conflict of interest or suspected policy violation, the expected response is to use the relevant disclosure or reporting procedure rather than conceal the issue. Accurate disclosures, audit oversight and responsible data handling can help strengthen accountability and stakeholder confidence.

10. RECOMMENDATIONS

- Conduct regular ethics and compliance training using realistic workplace examples.
- Explain policies in simple language and make them accessible to employees and relevant business partners.
- Keep whistleblower channels visible and reinforce protection against retaliation for good faith reports.
- Strengthen conflict-of-interest declarations and reviews for sensitive roles.
- Conduct risk-based internal audits and track corrective actions until completion.
- Review cybersecurity and privacy controls regularly and train staff on secure data handling.
- Make customer-support and complaint procedures easy to locate for each service.
- Analyse complaint patterns to identify service, product-quality or communication improvements.
- Encourage leaders to demonstrate fairness, integrity and accountability.
- Review policies periodically to reflect new laws, emerging risks and business changes.

11. CONCLUSION

Corporate governance and ethics are important to the responsible management of Reliance Industries Limited. Its Code of Conduct, board oversight, anti-corruption policy, whistleblower mechanism, risk controls and other governance policies provide a framework for

integrity, accountability and compliance. Reliance Industries Limited also focuses on sustainability, social responsibility and environmental protection as part of its commitment to responsible business development. By following ethical standards and continuously improving its governance policies, the company can achieve its business objectives while maintaining public trust.

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